

Cyclotour Guide Books

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Boxing a Bicycle For Public Transit

by Harvey Botzman

Note 1: It will take you longer to read these directions than to actually box your bike! Nonetheless, they are important to read!

Note 2: This page may take a bit longer time to load due to the pictures.

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© Harvey Botzman, 1993, 2002, 2007. Mr. Botzman is the author of 7 bicycle touring guide books:

Harvey will answer your questions on bicycle touring if you write to him at Cyclotour Guide Books,
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[Publication's editor may edit this article and if the editor is real nice include a title or two.]

*'Round Lake Ontario: A Bicyclist's Tour Guide, 'Round Lake Erie: A Bicyclist's Tour Guide,
'Round Lake Michigan: A Bicyclist's Tour Guide, 'Round Lake Huron: A Bicyclist's Tour Guide,
Erie Canal Bicyclist & Hiker Tour Guide, Finger Lakes Bicyclist's Tour Guide, and*

Public Transit to Your Starting Point

A very efficient and enjoyable way to start your cyclotour is to go to your starting point is via train, airline or bus. Of course if you live near by just ride to the start point.

Cyclotour Guides are designed so that a cyclotourist can begin and end at any point along the described route. Directions to and from major train stations, airports and bus terminals are provided in the text.

General Public Transit Rules

Each carrier - airlines, buses and railroads - have specific rules regarding the transport of bicycles. All carriers specify that bicycles must be boxed and shipped as baggage. Tandem, long wheel base recumbent and other large bicycles may not be able to be transported on airplanes or buses. Call the specific transportation company you intend to use for information.

Amtrak, VIA Rail and the airlines will sell you a box at the terminal. Phone the train and airline company at least 2 days in advance of your departure to make certain there are bike boxes at the station/terminal. Tell the station/terminal baggage person to reserve a bike box for you.

Bus companies in the U. S. A. do not have boxes for sale at their terminals. The major bus companies in the U. S. A. now (2006+) permit the transportation of bicycles in a canvas bag. Disassembly of the bicycle is necessary to fit a bike into these canvas bags. These bags are available from a number of pannier manufacturers, notably Arkel, and from your local bicycle shop.

A few bus companies in Canada allow you to plastic *bag* your bicycle. This is a very large plastic bag which wraps entirely around your bike. It folds down to a 6x6x3" (15.25x15.25x7.6 cm.) package and makes a wonderful ground cloth under your tent! Read below to find out how to obtain a bike box for bus transport.

You must have your own tools to pack a bike box or bike bag (cone wrench for the pedals and the proper size hex wrench for the handlebar stem). There are no bicycle tools at train stations, bus or airline terminals.

If you are traveling via train or plane then purchase the carrier's box. These boxes are designed for you to simply turn the handlebars and remove the pedals to fit a bicycle into the box. Very simple! Scroll down for detailed directions.

Using the carrier's bike box assures that the carrier can not claim that your box was too weak for holding a bicycle.

Bike Box Charges (As of December 20, 2007)				
Carrier	Bike Box Charge	Excess Bag Chg.	Tandems etc.	Notes
Amtrak	US \$15.00	US \$5.00 checked bike baggage fee	Tandems, yes; true folding bikes qualify as carry-on baggage	Only on trains w/ baggage cars.
VIARail	Free	CN \$20.00; tandems, \$40.00	Yes; folding bikes only as checked baggage	
A few long distance trains have facilities for carriage of unboxed bicycles.				
Commuter Trains	Free or ~\$5.00 for a <i>lifetime</i> permit	No	Sometimes	Usually a <i>lifetime</i> permit is needed
Airlines Domestic	US \$15.00+	US \$25.00+	Sometimes	No bikes on US or Canadian commuter flights. Make certain that bike boxes are available
Airlines: Overseas	US \$15.00+	Free	Excess bag chg. may apply	
Bus, US, Intercity	Your own, box	Sometimes	Must fit in baggage hold	Travels w/ passenger
Bus, Canada, Intercity	CN \$10.00, if available	CN \$30.00 + GST		
Bus: Local	Free	Free	Bike must fit on rack	Some local US & Canadian local transit buses have bike racks.

Other Notes:

On domestic US flights you will also have to pay an over limit (excess) baggage charge which can be as much as an additional US \$80.00. An excess baggage charge may apply to international flights.

Generally, smaller commuter airplanes do not have facilities for the transport of bicycle boxes on their planes. Your bike may be shipped on a different flight; possibly to a different airport than your destination.

Unless you have a folding bicycle or use a a bicycle bag Amtrak & VIARail only carry bicycles in baggage cars. This is significant! Not all Amtrak stations have baggage facilities! Make certain that both your originating and terminating stations have baggage facilities for the train which will be transporting both you and your bike. Otherwise your bike will be at one station and you at another.

In 2007, The League of American Bicyclists and Amtrak have refined Amtrak's folding bicycle carriage policy. Now any true folding bicycle can be carried, in the passenger compartment, as carry on luggage. The folding bicycle does not count as one piece of carry on luggage. As a matter of courtesy to your fellow passengers the bicyclist carrying a folding bicycle on to Amtrak's trains should pack the folded bicycle in a canvas bag or at the very least, one or two heavy duty contractor plastic trash bags. Amtrak's policy does not specify carrying the folded bicycle in a bag. I suggest this since bicycle grease on your fellow passengers' luggage, clothing or person will only build bad rapport for bicycling & bicyclists. Be civil. See Amtrak's bicycle baggage policy: <http://www.amtrak.com/>; go to the menu item, *Traveling with Amtrak*; and then to *Bring Your Bicycle Onboard*. Or go to our web page <http://www.cyclotour.com/amtrak.htm>

Amtrak's policy concerning bicycles in passenger cars is changing. As the National Railroad Corp. (Amtrak) purchases new or reconditions older passenger cars it is making provisions for the carriage of bicycles directly in the passenger compartment. Check with Amtrak. Some trains on California, Vermont & New York routes already have limited space for bicycles in the passenger compartments or carriage of unboxed bikes in baggage cars.

Write to Amtrak, Vice President, Marketing, 60 Massachusetts Ave., Washington DC 20002; your representative in the House of Representatives; both of your U.

S. Senators. Ask them to provide sufficient funds for all Amtrak trains to be equipped with passenger cars capable of carrying bicycles (on a reserved basis) in the passenger compartments and equip all Amtrak trains with baggage cars. It would not be outrageous also to ask the legislators to fund European/Japanese style super fast trains.

VIARail Commuter, GO (Ontario, Canada) trains; New York City's MTA trains; Chicago's commuter trains; and most municipal subway/rapid transit systems permit unboxed bicycles on their facilities during non rush hours. A permit is needed and must be obtained before boarding a train.

Bus travel presents a different problem. Bus line offices in the US do not stock bicycle boxes. In Canada you must call the bus station 5 days before departure to arrange for a bike box from Greyhound Administrative Services. Many Greyhound-Canada and Ontario-Northland bus stations in Canada now (2005) stock bike bags. No bag or box? Do one of the following:

1. Obtain a bicycle box from a bike shop;
2. Go to Amtrak/VIARail or an airport and obtain a box from those carriers;
3. Construct your own box from two or more smaller boxes;
4. Put your (unboxed) bike into the baggage compartment when the driver's back is turned. Many drivers suddenly disappear with the implication that you should do this heinous crime!

Many local buses (city buses) in the US and Canada now have bike racks on them. Use is usually free of charge. Ah! To be back traveling in Africa (Peace Corps '66-'69) where bikes are simply placed on top of the bus or lashed to the wall of the train's baggage car. How simple! And rarely were the bikes damaged.

For more information check these web sites:

Amtrak: www.amtrak.com

VIARail: www.viarail.com.ca

Greyhound US: www.greyhound.com

Greyhound-Canada: www.greyhound.com.ca

Airlines: Use a search engine to find a specific airline.

Municipalities: We usually list the availability of municipal buses with bike racks & other bicycle carriage facilities in our books. We strongly urge you to advocate for bike racks on your municipal buses.

How to Box Your Bike

The first time I boxed my bike I did it at home. I inserted extra cardboard into the box to reinforce the long sides of the box. I double sealed all edges using reinforced sealing tape. After loading the box into my station wagon and I brought it to the terminal the day before my departure date. It took an interminably long time, 2+ hours.

What a chore!

Make life simple for yourself. Pack the box at the terminal. Allow an extra 45-60 minutes to pack the box. It now takes me 15 minutes or less to pack a bike box.

Before you start on your cyclotour, take pictures of your bicycle, with and without panniers. Open the panniers and take some pictures of the contents of the panniers. If any damage occurs in transit you might need these pictures to assert your claim.

The Directions, finally!

Box Preparation

1. Obtain
 - a. Filament packing tape ~2" (~3.2cm) wide.
 - b. Cord (you have it in your panniers).
 - c. Black permanent felt tipped marker.
2. Obtain a bicycle box.
3. Clearly mark all six sides of the bike box. Use a black permanent marker. Write in big letters and numerals:
 - Destination:
 - Departure date:
 - Train or Flight number:
 - Ticket number:

Your name:

4. Make the box stand up!
 - a. Square the box and tape one end closed.
Use filament packing tape ~2" (~3.2cm) wide.
 - b. Some folks place a small triangle of cardboard at the closed end of the box to minimize bike in the box movement.

Bike Preparation

Or what you must do to your bike to make it fit into that slim box!

1. Tools
 - a. Hex wrenches for
 - 1) Brake cables
 - 2) Stem bolt
 - 3) New fangled pedals
 - b. Cone wrenches for old fangled pedals
 - c. A screw driver, flat & phillips, might also be necessary.
 - d. Tape or cord for tying up cranks.
2. Pedals & Cranks
 - a. Remove the pedals using a cone wrench; on newer bikes the pedals (cranks) are removed using a hex wrench.
 - b. Tape or tie one crank (if not removed) to a chain stay.
 - c. Put your pedals into a pannier.
3. Handlebars
 - a. Loosen the front brake cables.
 - b. Loosen the handlebar stem bolt.
 - c. Twist the handlebar stem. Usually you do not have to completely remove the stem.
 - d. Turn the handlebars so that they are parallel with the bike's top tube.
 - e. Wrap or tie the handlebars to the top tube or front rack.

4. Tires

a. If you are travelling by plane, deflate your tires to 20 psi. Airplane baggage compartments are not pressurized. You might find a burst tube at your destination!

5. Pack up your tools and put them back into your panniers! Check your panniers as separate piece(s) of baggage. Due to security regulations you are not be permitted to carry tool laden panniers into the passenger compartment of an airplane. Checking the panniers as separate pieces of baggage allow you to make a claim if the panniers are lost or if any items are missing from the panniers.

Into the Box the Bike Goes!

1. Wheel the bike into the bike box. Yippee!
2. Secure the bike by wedging your sleeping bag and a pannier between the bike and the box sides. Transportation companies officially forbid anything besides the bicycle to go into the bike box with the bike. Heck, your panniers are *permanently* attached to your bike!
 - a. Do **not** overload the box with heavy panniers.
 - b. Seal the open end of the Bike Box with filament packing tape.
 - c. You can place a few extra lengths of packing tape wherever you want on the box!
3. Bring the filled bike box to the baggage room and obtain a baggage claim check. Keep it with you. You will not be able to claim your bike without this claim check.
4. Time needed to disassemble your bike and pack the bike box: = 20-45 minutes.

At your Destination:

1. Claim your bicycle!
2. I have to preface this discussion of damage claims with the fact that my bike has never been damaged traveling via Amtrak and only once on a plane trip. Amtrak stores bikes in an upright position in its baggage cars. Airlines and bus lines store bikes on their side in baggage holds.

3. Check the bicycle box for possible in transit damage. If you see any damage to the exterior of the bike box, immediately take a picture of the damage and show the damage to the baggage personnel before you open the box.

4. Open the bike box, check your bike for any damage or missing items. If damage occurred, immediately show it to the baggage personnel and complete the damage claim form.

5. Assemble your bike. I hope you brought the hex wrenches and cone wrench!

6. After assembling your bike, take a short ride in the terminal to make certain there is no non-visible damage to the gearing, frame, wheels, etc. If you determine that there is some damage, take a picture of the damage and immediately show it to the baggage personnel. Ask for and complete the damage claim form.

a. If your bike was damaged: Find a local bicycle shop (look in the phone book.) Purchase the part, etc. Copy the receipt and make copies of your completed claim form. Send a copy of the receipt with the original claim form to the carrier. Mail home the original receipt and one copy of the claim form. It takes 2-6 weeks for most airlines, bus lines or Amtrak to begin to settle baggage damage claims so simply enjoy your cyclotour.

7; No damage! Hurrah! Yippee! Enjoy your cyclotour!



*Bicycle, small light panniers & sleeping bag ready to go into the bike box
The small box contains pedals & is used to wedge the front tire to limit bike movement.*

Note the Styrofoam protection for the derailleur.



A view inside the bike box.

How To Box A Bicycle, Text and Photographs

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